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is that people are trying to control the mouse with the touchscreen."

"The problem is the legacy way of doing things. Applications are still built keeping one-mouse-click applications in mind. We need to unlearn some of the things that we know. People need to think in terms of interfaces or desired touch points required (two, four or 40 touch points) and then build applications. It is important to understand that applications and content developed for mouse-based system can't be used for the touch interfaces," he adds.

The biggest flipside

The biggest deterrent in the widespread adoption of touchscreen technology is its cost. The bad news is that the cost is unlikely to drop in the immediate future. In fact, according to research firm DisplaySearch, touchscreen prices are expected to increase by eight per cent between 2007 and 2015. Increases in panel sizes and functionality mix will offset price declines for older panels.

"While prices will not be reduced on current or new touch technologies, the performance, optical clarity and capabilities of the sensor will become much more sophisticated. Until a suitable indium-tin-oxide (ITO) replacement is found, the price of touch panels will not change significantly. It is important to note that there are various indium-tin-oxide replacements in development but no market-proven replacement is available yet," reveals Sewell.

For multitouch technologies too, cost has been a major barrier. However, in electronics, cost goes down when vol-

umes increase. Going further, Tapadia believes that the volumes in this domain are likely to increase significantly as demand for such interfaces rises. Materials that help bring the cost down are also likely to emerge.

Key trends

Touchscreen technology is an extremely broad and segmented market witnessing a number of exciting trends:

Multi-touch will rule. The traditional touch-based surfaces offered a single touch interface, which allowed users to control only one point as is done with a mouse. However, of late, new interfaces are being developed and multi-touch is enabling next-generation interfaces to render a more intuitive experience. People have begun to understand and appreciate the use of multi-touch interfaces, which offer multiple touch points that make the surface viable for delivering a more intuitive and collaborative environment.

"In multi-touch we have developed three-four variants that offer different number of touch points. We have developed a surface using glass capacitive technology that supports six touch points, and another surface using optical infrared cell-based technology that supports about 40 touch points. The latter touchscreen solution is meant for developing large display sizes as on a small display you can't touch 40 points. A few interfaces that combine gestures with touch have also begun to emerge," says Tapadia.

It's the era of thumb-driven devices. Prior to Apple's launch of the iPhone, most of the touchscreen phones had to

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